Cappelletti (aka Hamilton)

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This convention is known by several names because Mike Cappelletti Sr., Fred Hamilton, and Julian Pottage (in the UK) are all credited for it. For simplicity I am just going to refer to it as Cappelletti.

Cappelletti is a defensive bidding convention after an opponent has opened 1NT. Overcaller's available conventional calls are as follows.

Overcall	Meaning
Double	Penalty with roughly 15+ points. (See also: Gates Double)
2♣	A one-suited hand (any suit, normally 6+ cards) with roughly 11-14 points.
2♦	At least 5-4 or 4-5 in hearts and spades, asks partner to correct to either major.
2♥	At least 5-5 in hearts and a minor.
2♠	At least 5-5 in spades and a minor.
2NT	At least 5-5 in clubs and diamonds.

Cappelletti is a popular convention against the weak 1NT, because it retains a natural double while still offering a way to compete with a variety of major-suited hands.

Responses to the Double

Advancer (overcaller's partner) is typically expected to pass. However, she may run with a 5+ card suit and a very weak hand.

Responses to the 2♣ Overcall

Response	Meaning
Pass	6+ clubs.
2♦	Artificial relay, asking partner to pass with diamonds or to bid 2♥/2♠/3♣ depending on which suit he has.
2♥	6+ hearts, nonforcing.
2♠	6+ spades, nonforcing.
2NT	10+ points, balanced and forcing for one round. Partner can raise to 3NT, or run to his suit at the 3-level.

Responses to the 2♦ Overcall

Advancer normally signs off in 2♥ or 2♠. With equal length in the majors, advancer should bid hearts.

Response	Meaning
Pass	6+ diamonds.
2♥	Natural preference, nonforcing.
2♠	Natural preference, nonforcing.
2NT	Artificial and forcing, roughly 10+ points. Overcaller's rebids are natural.

Responses to the 2♥ Overcall

Response	Meaning
Pass	A weak hand with tolerance for hearts.
2♠	Promises 6+ spades, no heart support, nonforcing.
2NT	Artificial, no heart support, asking for partner to bid his minor suit at the three level.
3♣	Promises 6+ good clubs, no heart support, nonforcing.
3♦	Promises 6+ good diamonds, no heart support, nonforcing.
3♥	Promises 3+ hearts, nonforcing.

Responses to the 2♠ Overcall

Response	Meaning
Pass	A weak hand with tolerance for spades.
2NT	Artificial, no spade support, asking for partner to bid his minor suit at the three level.
3♣	6+ good clubs, no spade support, nonforcing.
3♦	6+ good diamonds, no spade support, nonforcing.
3♥	6+ good hearts, no spade support, nonforcing.
3♠	3+ spades, nonforcing.

Responses to the 2NT Overcall

Response	Meaning
3♣	A weak hand with tolerance for clubs.
3♦	A weak hand with tolerance for diamonds. Tends to deny club support.
3♥	6+ good hearts, no support for either minor, nonforcing.
3♠	6+ good spades, no support for either minor, nonforcing.
3NT	To play.
4♣	3+ clubs, nonforcing.
4♦	3+ diamonds, nonforcing.

In Competition

In "25 More Bridge Conventions You Should Know", authors Barbara Seagram and David Bird suggest the following calls by advancer.[1]

- When 2♣ is doubled, then redouble is SOS.
- When 2♣ is overcalled, then double is for takeout. This promises some values since advancer could simply pass instead.
- When 2♦ is doubled, then redouble is SOS, asking overcaller to bid his better major.
- When 2♦ is overcalled, then double is for penalties.
- When 2♥ or 2♠ is doubled, then redouble is SOS, asking for partner's minor.
- When 2♥ or 2♠ is overcalled, then double is for penalties.

Modified Cappelletti

This variation of the Cappelletti convention uses 2♣ to show a minor single-suiter OR a major-minor two-suiter. This allows an immediate 2♥ or 2♠ overcall to show a single-suiter only.

However, it should be noted that Mike Cappelletti himself has been quoted as saying, "I can't stand it. Using 2♣ to show several possible hand types is inferior to just showing your major-minor two-suiters with 2♥ or 2♠. The problem with using 2♣ as first step in modified Cappelletti is that the opponents compete over 2♣, your side could wind up losing the major."[2]

At any rate, the structure is as follows.

Overcall	**Meaning**
Double	Still penalty.
2♣	A minor one-suiter, or at least 5-4 or 4-5 in a major and a minor. Relay to 2♦, after which opener will: • Pass with diamonds • Bid 2♥ with hearts and a minor • Bid 2♠ with spades and a minor • Bid 3♣ with clubs
2♦	Still a major two-suiter.
2♥	6+ hearts.
2♠	6+ spades.
2NT	Still a minor two-suiter.

Origins

Mike Cappelletti Sr. and Fred Hamilton (both American experts) and Julian Pottage in the UK are credited for this convention.

References

[1] Seagram, Barbara and David Bird. 25 More Bridge Conventions You Should Know. Toronto, Master Point Press, 2003.

[2] Daily Bulletin, Volume 50, Number 5. (March 13, 2007). ACBL.

See also

- Astro
  A defense to 1NT in which a double is for penalty, and 2♣/♦ overcalls are artificial.
- Brozel
  A defense to 1NT in which a double shows a one-suited overcall, and all 2-level bids show specific 2-suited hands.